All Party Primaries (Initiative 25-12)

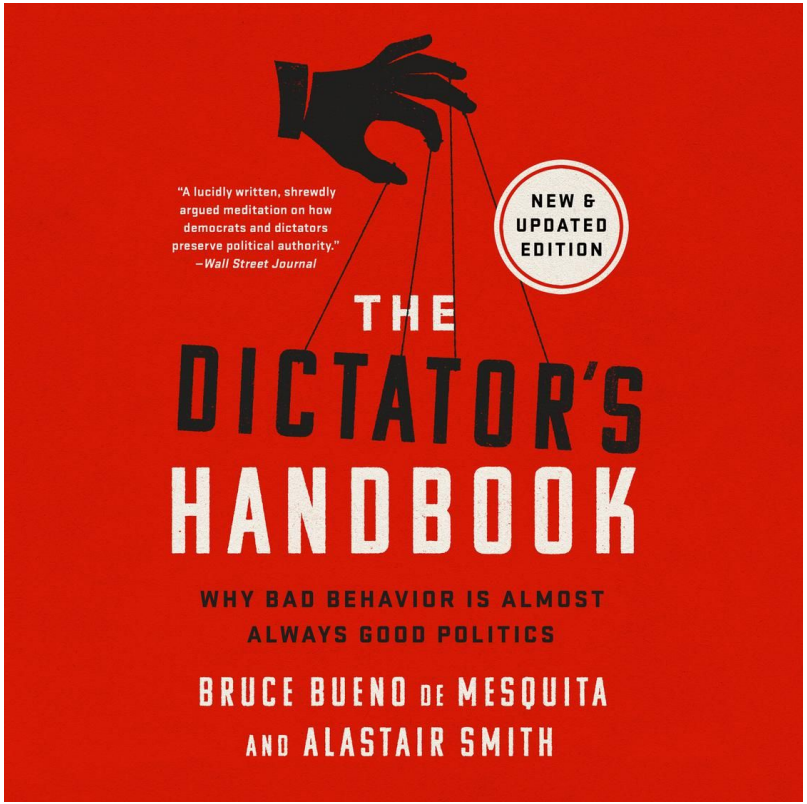
COALITION FOR HEALTHY DEMOCRACY

Democracy works best when we all participate

… and when Democratic candidates and voters aren’t sidelined by low-turnout primaries

Broad Participation Protects Democracy

- Leaders govern differently depending on how many voters they must satisfy to stay in power.
- Small electorates → factional politics.
- Large electorates → broader coalitions and accountability.
- Today, many U.S. elections are effectively decided in low-turnout primaries.



Our Unhealthy Democracy in MA

- Last decade: **52% (696 races) were completely uncontested.**
- Many more **effectively decided in low-turnout primaries.**
- 65% of voters are unenrolled in a party.
- Massachusetts ranks last in competitiveness of legislative elections.
- In 2024 72% of races for Massachusetts state legislature were decided by 20% of the voters.

Ballotpedia's State Legislative Competitiveness Index in Massachusetts, 2010-2024

Year	Rank
2010	39 / 44
2012	44 / 44
2014	39 / 44
2016	44 / 44
2018	44 / 44
2020	44 / 44
2022	44 / 44
2024	44 / 44

2026 MA STATE SENATE SPECIAL ELECTION RESULTS

CURRENT SYSTEM

DEMOCRAT PRIMARY

VANNA HOWARD (D) 3,339 VOTES — Dem Primary Winner

RODNEY ELLIOTT (D) 2,375 VOTES

REPUBLICAN PRIMARY

SAM MEAS (R) 372 VOTES — GOP Primary Winner

Sam Meas advanced to the general Election, despite receiving 2,000 **fewer** Votes than Rodney Elliott

IF WE HAD ALL PARTY PRIMARIES

ALL PARTY PRIMARY

VANNA HOWARD (D)	3,339 VOTES — Most Votes
RODNEY ELLIOTT (D)	2,375 VOTES — 2nd Most Votes
SAM MEAS (R)	372 VOTES

Both Advance

If we used All Party Primaries, Rodney Elliot would have advanced instead of Sam Meas, because he received more votes

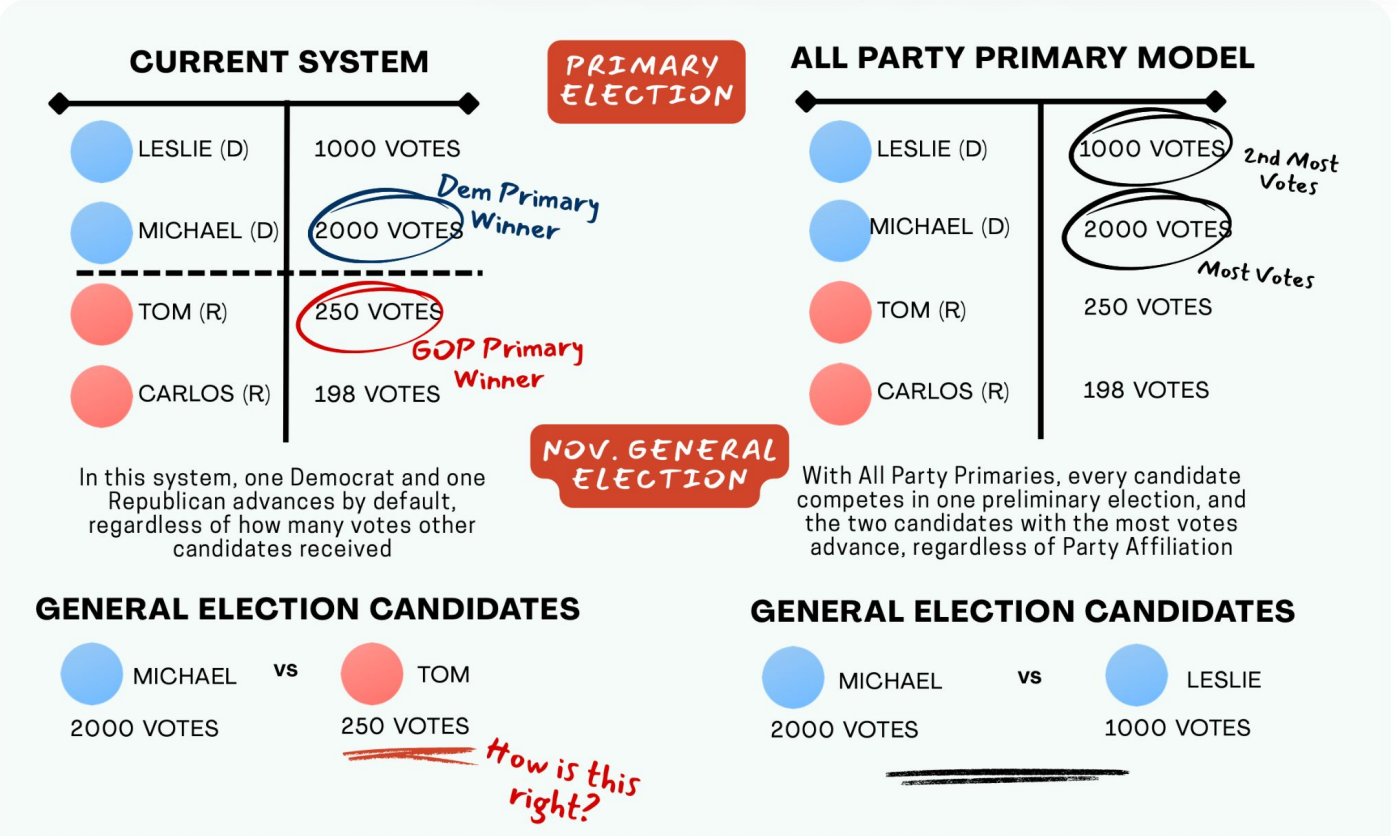
GENERAL ELECTION CANDIDATES

VANNA HOWARD (D) 3,339 VOTES **vs** SAM MEAS (R) 372 VOTES — How is this fair?

GENERAL ELECTION CANDIDATES

VANNA HOWARD (D) 3,339 VOTES **vs** RODNEY ELLIOTT (D) 2,375 VOTES

Deep Blue Districts



What All-Party Primaries Will Do

- Candidates appear on a single primary ballot, regardless of party. **Similar to mayoral and city council elections.**
- All voters — including unenrolled — vote in a primary with all candidates, **voting for one candidate in each race.**
- The top two vote-getters advance to the general election.
- Each **candidates' political party** will be listed next to their name. Parties can make **endorsements** that will be listed on the ballot.
- Statewide office (Gov, AG, etc), state legislature, US House of Representatives and US Senate.
- **Gov. and Lt. Gov run together as a "ticket"** and compete in the primary as a "ticket" - important for effective governance.

EXAMPLE PRIMARY BALLOT: State Senate, First District	
All registered voters receive the same ballot. **Vote for ONE**. The top two vote-getters advance to the general election, regardless of party.	
◯	**Alfred Anderson**, Democrat *Endorsed by:* ***Democratic Party, MA Voter Party, Merrimack Valley Project, Working Families Party***
◯	**Bella Bonilla**, Democrat *Endorsed by:* ***Forward Party***
◯	**Carla Choi,** Republican *Endorsed by:* ***Republican Party***
◯	**David DiSalvo**, Libertarian Party *Endorsed by:* ***Libertarian Party***
◯	**Frank Fitzgerald,** Unenrolled *Endorsed by: No party endorsement*

How Massachusetts Voters Benefit

- Fairness and freedom. All voters, including independents/unenrolled, have **full ability to participate** in the primary with a vote all contests.

- More information. Endorsements on the ballot tells voters **which groups are backing which candidates.**

- Participation. No votes are taken for granted; parties and candidates must **compete for all voters**.

- Turnout. Higher and **more diverse turnout** — especially among younger and unenrolled voters who lean Democratic.

- Reflective. Increases **diversity and reflectiveness** of state legislature.

Stronger Competition, Strong Candidates

- More exposure for candidates to make clear their vision.
- Broader coalitions with support from the full electorate — not just primary voters.
- Mandates to govern.

Competitive structures also increase turnout and expand the electorate.

Example: NYC Mayor, 2025

- Highest turnout in 60+ years.
- Surge of new voters.
- Winner earned a clear majority mandate.
- Outside spending did not predetermine the outcome.

Competition strengthens legitimacy — and **strengthens the party.**

Democratic Town/City Committees

What does this mean for Democratic Town and City Committees?

- More November engagement around Democratic ideas.
- Candidates must speak to the full district, not just primary voters.
- Stronger, more legitimate Democratic nominees.
- Ensure Beacon Hill hears from the full electorate — not just primary voters.
- Likely increased Democratic Party registration because all options on the ballot - no need to be ‘unenrolled.”

What This is Not

- Not Ranked Choice Voting (but compatible)

- Not anti-party (party labels & endorsements on the ballot)

- Not California (safeguards prevent vote-splitting)

- Not “pro-moderate” (it is pro-**voter**)

Frequently Asked Questions

- **Is this ranked choice voting (RCV)?**
  - No, this is not RCV but it would be compatible with RCV.
- **Who benefits from the status quo and might oppose this?**
  - Candidates who rely on low-turnout partisan primaries instead of facing the full November electorate. In deep blue districts, that can mean a Republican advances with a few hundred votes while a Democrat with thousands more is excluded.
- **Could one party "split the vote"?**
  - Exceptionally rare: happened only three times in over 2,000 races.
  - Safeguards: party endorsements on the ballot + write-in option in the general.
- **How would Governor & Lt. Governor work?**
  - They would run as a joint ticket starting in the primary — like in Maryland, Illinois, and Alaska.
- **Will Republicans become "kingmakers" in Democratic districts—or vice versa?**
  - No. In many deep blue districts, this reform actually reduces the chance that a fringe Republican automatically advances to November simply because they were unopposed in their party.

Endorsements:

Organizations

NAACP, New England Area Conference
Massachusetts Women of Color Coalition
Veterans for All Voters
UltraViolet Action
Worcester Indivisible
Fitchburg Indivisible
Brookfield Fights Fear
Holden Democratic Town Committee
Democrats of Clark University
Central MA Citizens Climate Lobby
Massachusetts Forward Party
Massachusetts Green-Rainbow Party

Individuals

Gov. Deval Patrick
State Auditor Diana DiZoglio
Tanisha Sullivan, NAACP
Mayor Jon Mitchell
Former Lieutenant Governor Kerry Healey
Former Congressman Joe Kennedy III
Danielle Allen, Democracy Advocate
Kevin Johnson, Executive Director, Election Reformers Network
Steve Grossman, former Chair, Massachusetts Democratic Party and Democratic National Committee
Jennifer Nassour, former Chair, Massachusetts Republican Party
Nathan Lockwood, Founder, Rank the Vote

Democracy works best when we all participate... and when our votes matter.

Thank You

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More Information

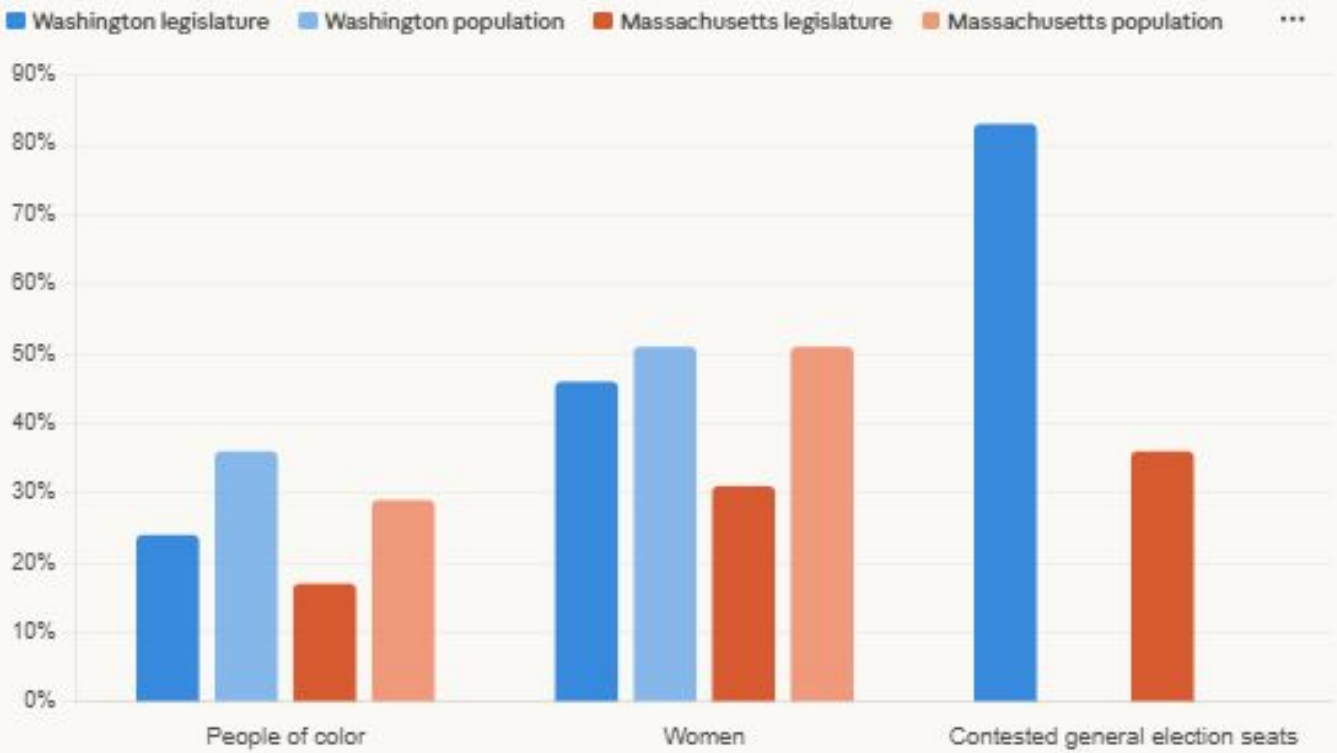
Comparisons

	Nebraska	Louisiana	California	Washington	Alaska	Massachusetts
NCSL Description	Nonpartisan	All-Comers, aka "Jungle Primary"	Multi-party (aka Top-Two)	Multi-party (aka Top-Two)	Multi-party (aka Top-Four)	If ballot initiative passes: All-party Primary (aka Top-Two)
Process	Top two vote-getters move to general election	If candidates get 50%+1 in primary, no general election	Top two vote-getters move to general regardless of party	Top two vote-getters move to general regardless of party	Top four vote-getters move to general regardless of party	Top two vote-getters move to general regardless of party
Candidate Party Registration or "Preference"	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party Endorsements on the Ballot?	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
Voter Registration (June 2025)	Dem: 26.3% GOP: 49.6% Other / No Party: 24.1%	Dem: 36.8% GOP: 35.2% Other / No Party: 27.9%	Dem: 45.3% GOP: 25.2% Other / No Party: 29.5%	No party registration	Dem: 12.2% GOP: 24.4% Other / No Party: 64.71%	Dem: 25.8% GOP: 8.4% Other / No Party: 65.7%%

Comparing States: Money In Campaigns

	California	Washington	Alaska	Massachusetts (projected with All Party Primaries)
All-party primary	Yes (top-two)	Yes (top-two)	Yes (top-four + RCV)	Yes (top-two)
Media costs	Very high	Moderate	Low	Moderate
Interest-group density	High	Moderate	Low	Moderate → increasing
Electoral competitiveness	High / variable	Moderate	Low–moderate	Moderate (↑ from low)
State contribution limits	$11,800 (leg); $78,400 Gov	$1,200	No limits	$1,000
Outside spending on elections growth after 2010	Very high	Moderate	Low	Currently minimal → projected moderate

WA and MA Legislature Diversity/Inclusion



Sources: WA diversity from Cascade PBS & WA Community Alliance (2022-2024); MA diversity from MA Women's Caucus (2025) & state reporting. WA competitiveness from Ballotpedia (2024); MA competitiveness provided by campaign. Population data from U.S. Census / WCA.

Top 2
Lock-out Data

Complete List of Lockout Elections 2008-2024 in CA and WA (2000+ elections)

2012 CA-31 U.S. House Race
Gary Miller (Incumbent, R) and Bob Dutton (R) advanced; incumbent Miller won
4 Democrats were in the race, no Democrat advanced
Democrats as a group did not receive majority of total vote across candidates, despite being a D+2 district

2016 Washington State Treasurer (statewide)
Open seat. Duane Davidson (R) and Michael Waite (R) advanced
3 Democrats were in race, no Democrat advanced
Washington is a Democratic-leaning statewide electorate

2022 California State Senate District 4
Open seat. Tim Robertson (D) and Marie Alvarado-Gil (D) advanced
8 Republicans were in the race and did not advance, despite as a group having the majority of votes

Nancy Pelosi on CA Gubernatorial- NYT

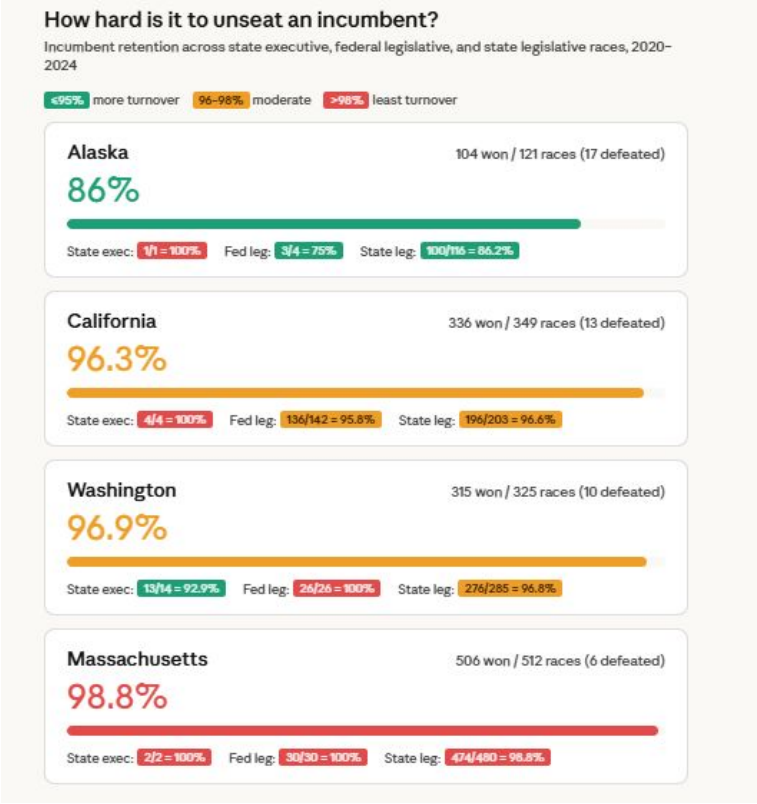
At the convention last weekend, California Democrats celebrated Ms. Pelosi as she neared retirement. But she made it clear that she still held sway as she tamped down concerns about the governor's race.

"We will have a Democratic governor for our state," Ms. Pelosi said in an interview. "And some reporters have said, 'Well, what about two Republicans?' That won't happen."

She said she had spoken to nearly all of the candidates for governor. While she has not endorsed anyone, she also did not tell any of them to drop out. But she firmly believed the field would sort itself out. "I'm very confident," she said. "I've done this a long time."

Fairness, Inclusion, and Participation Data

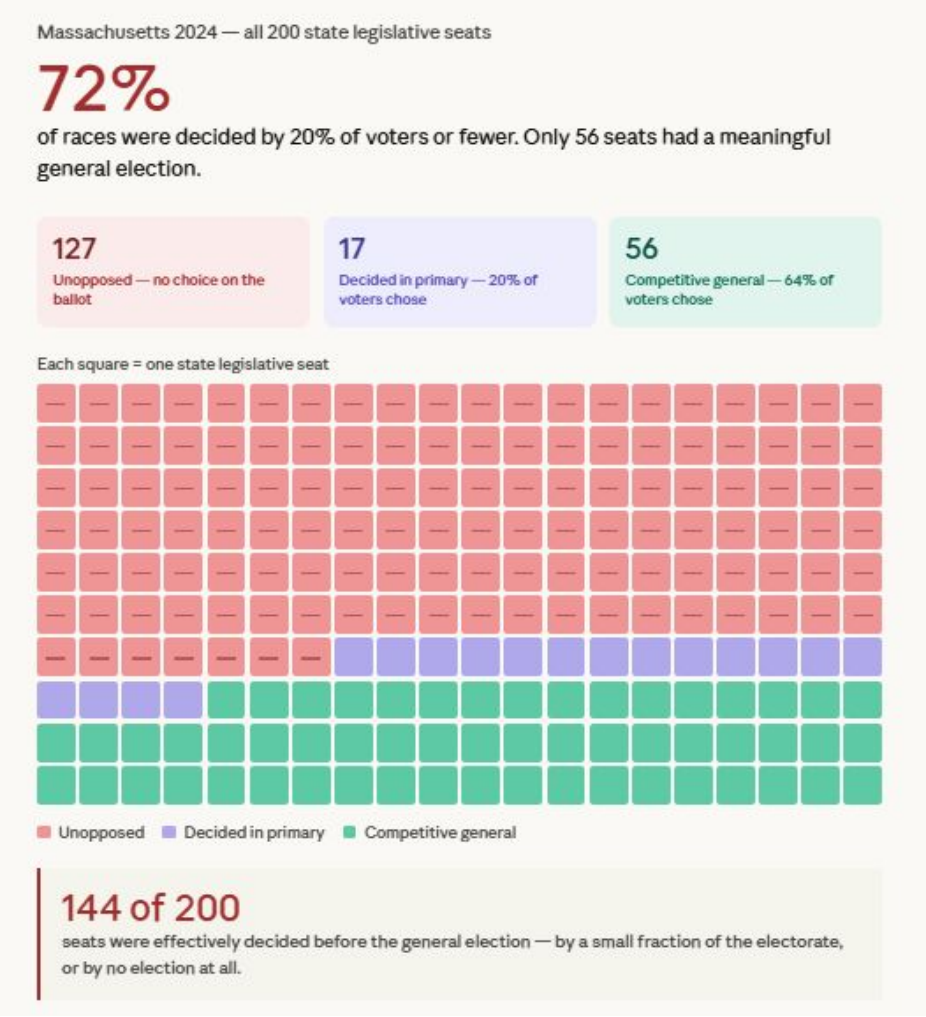
Incumbency Retention Rates



Alaska stands out clearly — across 121 races from 2020–2024, 17 incumbents lost, for an 86.0% retention rate. That's driven almost entirely by state legislative turnover (100 of 116 state leg incumbents won, or 86.2%), with the Peltola loss adding to it on the federal side.

California and Washington land in a similar band at 96.3% and 96.9%, both in the yellow zone. California's turnover comes from both federal (6 House members lost across three cycles) and state legislative races. Washington's comes mostly from state legislative churn and one state executive loss in 2020.

Massachusetts is the most locked-in at 98.8% — just 6 incumbents lost out of 512 races across the entire period, and all 6 were in the state legislature. No federal or statewide executive incumbent lost in any of the three cycles. Both California and Washington were in a similar place prior to their change.



Massachusetts currently has the fewest contested elections in the country, so most races are decided by 20% of the electorate.

All Party Primaries would reduce the red and blue and increase the green, where 64% of the electorate decides.

Every shift from red or blue to green increases the number of people and diversity of electorate deciding the election, a major participation gain.

Projecting the same percentage of contested general elections from Washington, Massachusetts shifts from **144 races with no general election competition** to **only 40** without a general election competition.

This is a dramatic increase in races where there are far more people with greater diversity deciding the election, a major participation gain.

Statements of Support

“The political process is broken because the voices of too many people are not heard. Too often voters from underserved communities of color and the working class are treated as an afterthought. The NAACP New England Area Conference supports All-Party Primaries because we believe that every voter deserves a system that gives them a real voice in choosing who represents them.” -- Tanisha Sullivan, President, NAACP New England Area Conference

“Veterans stepped forward to defend our democracy overseas. We shouldn’t have to fight for a meaningful vote here at home. All-Party Primaries are about giving every voter—regardless of party—an equal say in choosing the leaders who make decisions for all of us.” -- Eric Bronner, Navy Veteran and Founder of Veterans for All Voters.

“[One ballot initiative] really strikes at the heart of the democratic process — creating an all-party state primary… Reform-minded advocates and many political scientists agree that the present system isn’t working… A vote for open primaries — should it appear on the 2026 state ballot — would ensure a more inclusive, competitive political process.” -- Lowell Sun Editorial Board